Question 2 Prose: Mark Scheme & Model Answer

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Mark Scheme and Model Answer

The best way to improve any essay is to know how you are assessed, and what skills you are being assessed on. This page has been created to give you a sense of what examiners are looking for in a full-mark response. It contains:

- Overview
- Mark scheme
- Example task
- Model answer
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Overview

Question 2 (Prose) will require you to answer a question based on an extract printed on the exam paper. You will be asked to explore, or analyse, how a writer has achieved particular meanings or ideas in the passage. Your response must also be supported with direct quotations or close reference to the text, which should be integrated into your response.

Mark scheme

The mark scheme for any question in Literature in English is quite broad and can seem difficult to understand. This is because there is no "correct answer" for any essay: the exam board does not provide points that need to be included in any essay; instead, examiners use the mark scheme to place an answer into a level.

The questions in Paper 4 are equally weighted, and each question tests all four assessment objectives.

In simple terms, to achieve the highest marks (Band 8 = 23–25 marks), this means:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

	• This means using quotations and indirect references to the text to support your views or arguments
AO2	• Sustain a critical understanding of the text by showing individuality and insight • This means showing that you understand the main ideas, settings, events and characters, and that you appreciate the deeper meanings of the text
AO3	• Respond sensitively and in considerable detail to the way the writer achieves her/his effects • This means that you are able to explore how writers use language, structure and form to convey impressions and ideas
AO4	• Sustain a personal and evaluative engagement with the task and text • This means that you are able to give a personal response to the question and text, and support your response with references to the text

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Although there are four specific assessment objectives assessed in this task, it is not the case that a certain number of marks are awarded for any one objective. Instead, the examiners are looking for a well-constructed and coherent essay that seamlessly combines all of the skills covered by the assessment objectives.

Example task

The following task is written in the style of a question you might get on your exam paper. It is based on the non-fictional memoir "H is for Hawk" by Helen Macdonald. The annotations indicate the kind of things you should be looking for when reading the unseen prose passage in the exam for the first time.

Read carefully the extract from a non-fictional memoir. The writer is buying a bird of prey, which she intends to train. Here she sees the hawk for the first time.

In what ways does the writer powerfully convey the impact the hawk has on her?

To help you answer this question, you might consider:

- How the writer portrays waiting to see the hawk

about the hawk

Time passed on the Scottish quay and brightness moved in from the sea. Then a man was walking towards us, holding two enormous cardboard boxes like a couple of oversized suitcases. Strangely alien suitcases that didn't seem to obey the laws of physics, because as he walked they moved unpredictably, in concert neither with his steps nor with gravity. *Whatever is in them is moving*, I thought with a little thump of my heart. He set the boxes down, ran his hand through his hair. "I'm meeting another falconer here in a bit. He's having the younger bird. Yours is the older. Bigger too," he said. "So." He ran his hand through his hair again, exposing a long talon scratch across his wrist, angry at its edges and scurled with dried blood. "We'll check the ring numbers against the Article 10s," he explained, pulling a sheaf of yellow paper from the rucksack and unfolding two of the official forms that accompany captive-bred rare birds throughout their lives. "Don't want you ending up with the wrong bird."

Suggests something out of this world

She is nervous

Danger

We noted the numbers. We stared down at the boxes, at their parcel-tape handles, their doors of thin plywood and hinges of carefully tied string. Then he knelt on the concrete, untied a hinge on the smaller box and squinted into its dark interior. A sudden thump of feathered shoulders and the box shook as if someone had punched it, hard, from within. "She's got her hood off," he said, and frowned. That light, leather hood was to keep the hawk from fearful sights. Like us.

Repetition of "thump"

Suggests something powerful

She starts to think what the bird is experiencing

Another hinge untied. Concentration. Infinite caution. Daylight irrigating the box. Scratching talons, another thump. Then another. *Thump.* The air turned syrupy, slow, flecked with dust. The last few seconds before a battle. And with the last bow pulled free, he reached inside, and amidst a whirring, chaotic clatter of wings and feet and talons and a high-pitched twittering and it's all happening at once, the man pulls an enormous, *enormous* hawk out of the box and in a strange coincidence of world and deed a great flood of sunlight drenches us and everything in its brilliance and fury. The hawk's wings, barred and beating, the sharp fingers of her dark-tipped primaries cutting the air, her feathers raised like the scattered quills of a fretful porpentine. Two enormous eyes. My heart jumps sideways. She is a conjuring trick. A reptile. A fallen angel. A griffon from the pages of an illuminated bestiary. Something bright and distant, like gold falling through water. A broken marionette of wings, legs and light-splashed feathers.

She is wearing jesses, and the man holds them. For one awful, long moment she is hanging head-downward, wings open, like a turkey in a butcher's shop, only her head is turned right-way-up and she is seeing more than she has even seen before in her whole short life. Her world was an aviary no larger than a living room. Then it was a box. But now it is this; and she can see *everything*: the point-source glitter on the waves, a diving cormorant a hundred yards out; pigment flakes under wax on the lines of parked cars; far hills and the heather on them and miles and miles of sky where the sun spreads on dust and water and illegible things moving in it that are white scraps of gulls. Everything starting and new-stamped on her entirely astonished brain.

String of short sentences and repetition of "thump" - getting closer

She is both enchanted and afraid

Like a mythical creature

She imagines what the hawk is seeing and feeling

Model Answer

Below you will find a full-mark model answer for this task. The commentary labelled in each section of the essay illustrates how and why it would be awarded full marks. Despite the fact it is an answer to the above question, the commentary is relevant to any unseen prose essay, because it models how to structure an answer incorporating the relevant assessment objectives.

Unannotated model answer

The writer powerfully conveys the impact the hawk has on her by describing the sense of anticipation she has while waiting for the hawk, and then through detailed imagery to describe the bird itself and its transition from its small and confined world to being something that sees and experiences everything everywhere all at once.

At the start of the passage, the writer portrays waiting to see the hawk with anticipation and tension. Her encounter with the hawk is clearly very meaningful for her, as she begins to identify with it emotionally before she even sees it. Initially, the content of the boxes seems to have some kind of supernatural power, as she describes them as "alien suitcases" that defy "the laws of physics". This gives the impression that whatever is in the boxes is not of this world. The unpredictability of their movement is echoed in the "little thump" of the writer's heart, as she doesn't know what to expect and is nervous. There is also a sense of danger implied in the fact that the writer's hawk is "bigger" and in the description of the talon scratch on the falconer's wrist, "angry" at its edges and crusted with "dried blood". This further implies the exciting yet dangerous feeling the writer is experiencing.

The onomatopoeic "thump" of the writer's heart is repeated in the middle of the extract in the "sudden thump of feathered shoulders" from the box, which shook as though someone had "punched it, hard". This implies that there is something powerful inside. However, the speaker begins to identify with the creature as she realises that we, as humans, are the ones to strike fear, rather than the other way around.

The use of short sentences to build the sense of anticipation the writer feels continues with "another hinge untied", "concentration" and "infinite caution". Again, the repetition of "thump" along with "scratching talons" gives the impression of an enormous beast getting closer. Her first sight of the hawk has the most powerful impact on her, as she repeats "enormous" twice, along with "a great flood of sunlight" as though the hawk has been sent from heaven in an oxymoronic "brilliance and fury". The writer appears to be both enchanted and afraid in equal measure. The writer then uses a string of metaphors for the hawk as "a conjuring trick", a "reptile", a "fallen angel" and "a griffon from the pages of an illuminated bestiary". This suggests the writer sees the hawk as a mythical creature direct from the pages of a book, and that it therefore cannot be real. It is as though the hawk has come to her from a different realm.

The impact of the hawk on the writer also means that she is interested in how our world would look to the hawk. The hawk has been released from the narrow world of the aviary and now she is "seeing more than she has ever seen before". The writer then picks out little details that the hawk might see, such as the "glitter on the waves" and "pigment flakes under wax on the lines of parked cars". These small details emphasise that the hawk is seeing these things for the first time, and it is astonishing.

Overall, the writer powerfully conveys the impact the hawk had on her by describing both her reaction and the hawk's reaction to seeing and experiencing things for the very first time, and how wonderful and frightening that can be.

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